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GST 105: Humanities - Art, Literature, Music and the Examined Life

A guided tour of the humanities that gives you something real to say in the exam

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Humanities questions look broad, so students answer with vague generalities. This pack gives you concrete definitions, examples and evaluation language for literature, visual art, music, theatre and philosophy, plus a method for analysing a work you have never seen before.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define the humanities and explain why they matter beyond 'self-expression'.
- Analyse a poem, painting, piece of music or play using a repeatable framework.
- Explain the relationship between art, culture and society with Nigerian examples.
- Write a short evaluative answer that makes a claim, gives evidence and acknowledges complexity.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Why the humanities exist

The humanities study human experience and the meanings people make through language, image, sound, performance, belief and argument.

They are not soft subjects. They require close reading, historical context and judgment under uncertainty - the same skills you need to interpret a legal case, a patient's story or a business rumour.

The disciplines you will meet include literature, linguistics, history, philosophy, religious studies, music, theatre and film, and visual arts.

- Literature: how language creates meaning, character and value.

- History: how evidence is selected and interpreted to explain change.
- Philosophy: how concepts and arguments are tested.
- Music and theatre: how performance shapes emotion and community.

Analysing a poem without fear

Use the SOS method: Subject, Occasion, Speaker - then move to form and language.

1. Subject: what is the poem about in one sentence?
2. Occasion: what situation or moment triggered it?
3. Speaker: who is talking, and is it the poet?
4. Form: stanzas, line length, rhyme, rhythm, free verse.
5. Language: diction, imagery, metaphor, simile, personification, repetition.
6. Tone: the speaker's attitude, supported by specific words.
7. Theme: what the poem suggests about life, not just what happens.

> **Avoid the summary trap**
> Retelling the poem is not analysis. Every claim about meaning needs a quotation and a comment on the effect of the language.

Visual art and music as evidence

You do not need to be an artist to analyse art. You need to describe what is there before interpreting it.

- Visual art: subject matter, composition, colour, light, texture, scale, setting, and the artist's likely intention.
- Nigerian reference points: Nok terracotta, Benin bronzes, Igbo uli body painting, contemporary artists such as Ben Enwonwu and Njideka Akunyili Crosby.
- Music: instrument, rhythm, melody, tempo, dynamics, lyrics, call-and-response and context of performance.
- Theatre: script, performance, staging, costume, audience and director's choices.
- Always separate description from interpretation: 'The dominant colour is red' is description; 'The red suggests danger' is interpretation.

Writing an answer that earns marks

Humanities answers are judged on accuracy, evidence and reasoning, not on how emotional they sound.

1. Make a direct claim in the first sentence.
2. Define your key term immediately.
3. Give one concrete example - a text, artwork, event or practice.
4. Explain how the example supports the claim.
5. Add one qualification or counter-point.
6. Close with a sentence that answers the question, not with 'in conclusion'.

Useful sentence starters

This suggests that... / The choice of... implies... / A limitation of this reading is... / This matters because... Avoid 'it is a very interesting work' with no follow-up.

What the humanities study, and why it is not "soft"

The humanities study human meaning: how people make, argue, worship, govern and remember. Their evidence is texts, artefacts, performances, institutions and testimony, and their method is interpretation disciplined by argument. The charge that this is "soft" usually means the evidence is not numerical, which is a description, not a criticism.

Interpretation is not arbitrary. A reading of a novel, a constitution or a religious practice must be supported by what is there, must account for the strongest contrary reading, and must be offered in terms another scholar could dispute. Those three requirements are as demanding as any laboratory protocol.

The humanities also matter instrumentally. Law, journalism, diplomacy, education, publishing and public administration all run on the ability to read carefully, argue precisely and understand why people act as they do - the exact skills this course begins to build.

The disciplines and their questions

Philosophy asks what is real, what we can know and how we should act. Literature studies how language makes meaning and pleasure. History reconstructs and interprets the past from partial evidence. Linguistics analyses language as a system. Religious studies examines belief and practice without assuming the truth of any tradition. Fine and performing arts study making and reception. Each has its own standards of evidence; a historian cannot accept a claim because it is beautiful, and a literary critic cannot settle an interpretation by counting.

Knowing which discipline you are in determines what counts as a good answer. The commonest first-year error is writing a moral essay in a history paper, or a summary in a philosophy paper. Ask of every paragraph: what kind of claim is this, and what would support it in this discipline?

The two-question habit

For any humanities source ask: what is this claiming, and what would make it wrong? The second question is what separates study from reading.

Culture, identity and the Nigerian humanities

Nigerian humanities scholarship has been shaped by debates about colonial knowledge, language, and the responsibility of the writer and scholar. The argument over whether African literature should be written in European languages, the recovery of oral traditions as legitimate sources, and the critique of anthropology as a colonial instrument are all part of the field's formation.

These debates are not historical curiosities. They determine how a student today treats oral testimony, whether a festival is described as heritage or as contemporary practice, and whose categories are used to organise a course. A good answer makes its own categories visible.

Culture here is not decoration. It is the shared system of meaning through which people interpret work, authority, gender, time and death; the humanities study how those systems are produced and contested.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Reading a source as a humanist

You are given a 1960s newspaper editorial about decolonisation. Produce a discipline-appropriate reading.

1. Establish the source: author, outlet, date, intended reader.
2. Identify the claim and the argument supporting it.
3. Note the vocabulary doing ideological work - words that assume what they should prove.
4. Place it in context: what was happening that makes this intervention timely?
5. Offer two readings and say which the evidence better supports.
6. State the limit of a single editorial as evidence for public opinion.

> **What to carry forward**
> Source, claim, language, context, competing readings, limits. That is a humanities method in six steps.

2. Answering "why study the humanities?" without cliché

A scholarship interview question that most candidates answer with "because it makes us human".

1. Name the concrete skill: constructing an argument from ambiguous evidence.
2. Give an example of a decision that requires it - interpreting a contract, a report, a testimony.
3. Acknowledge the economic objection honestly.
4. Show the transfer: the same skill appears in law, policy, media and management.
5. Avoid grand claims you cannot support.

> **What to carry forward**
> Defend the humanities by describing what graduates can actually do.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish the kinds of evidence used in history and in literary criticism, and explain why the distinction matters.

15 marks

1. History: documents, testimony, material remains, interpreted for what happened and why.
2. Literary criticism: the text itself, read for how meaning is produced.
3. Explain the different burdens: causal adequacy versus interpretive plausibility.
4. Show the consequence for a student answer: counting cannot settle an interpretation; beauty cannot settle a fact.

Q2. Discuss the view that the humanities are a luxury in a developing economy.

20 marks

1. State the strongest version of the objection.
2. Identify its assumption: that value equals immediate measurable output.
3. Show the dependence of institutions on humanities skills.
4. Concede the funding pressure is real.
5. Conclude with a defensible position on priorities, not a slogan.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Refusing to engage the objection. Marks come from taking it seriously.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Humanities. Disciplines studying human meaning, expression and institutions through interpretation.

Interpretation. An account of meaning supported by evidence and open to dispute.

Primary source. Material produced in the period or by the people being studied.

Secondary source. Later commentary that interprets primary material.

Hermeneutics. The theory and method of interpretation, especially of texts.

Discourse. A patterned way of speaking and writing that shapes what can be said.

Colonial knowledge. Knowledge produced within and for colonial power, shaping categories still in use.

Oral tradition. Knowledge transmitted through speech, performance and memory.

Canon. The works a discipline treats as central, always contestable.

Ideology. Assumptions embedded in language and practice that make arrangements seem natural.

Aesthetics. The study of beauty, taste and artistic value.

Interdisciplinarity. Combining methods from more than one discipline to address a question.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Disciplines

Questions and evidence.

- Write the central question of three humanities disciplines.
- Match five sources to the discipline that would use them.
- Identify one claim that no discipline could test.

Week 2 - Sources

Reading closely.

- Analyse one primary source in six steps.
- Mark vocabulary doing ideological work.
- State the limits of the source.

Week 3 - Debate

Nigerian contexts.

- Summarise the language debate in 200 words.
- Take a position with evidence.
- Name the strongest objection.

Week 4 - Essay

Discipline-appropriate writing.

- Plan a 20-mark answer.
- Check every paragraph's claim type.
- Write and edit to the word limit.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any general introduction to the humanities covering disciplines and methods.
- A collection of Nigerian humanities essays on culture, language and decolonisation.
- A short guide to source analysis for arts and social science students.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between description and interpretation in art analysis?

Answer: Description states what can be observed (colour, shapes, composition). Interpretation explains what those choices might mean. Interpretation needs descriptive evidence.

2. Name three elements of a poem you would discuss in an analysis.

Answer: Form, imagery and tone are three. You could also discuss diction, rhythm, rhyme or theme, but every claim should be tied to a quotation.

3. Why is the humanities not the same as 'opinion'?

Answer: Humanities scholarship uses evidence, context, method and argument. Opinions can be offered, but they must be supported and open to challenge.

4. Give one Nigerian example of visual art and explain its significance.

Answer: The Benin bronzes are metal plaques and sculptures from the Kingdom of Benin, significant for their craftsmanship and for debates about repatriation of looted heritage.

5. What does 'tone' mean in literary analysis?

Answer: The speaker's attitude toward the subject or audience, revealed through word choice, rhythm and images.

6. How should you discuss a work you have not studied before?

Answer: Describe what is present, identify patterns, connect them to context and make a careful interpretive claim. Do not invent biographical facts.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read one poem and annotate subject, speaker, form, imagery and tone.
- [ ] Visit a campus exhibition or browse a Nigerian art collection online and describe three works without interpreting them yet.
- [ ] Listen to one Nigerian classical or contemporary piece and write four lines on instrumentation and mood.
- [ ] Write a 250-word answer to 'Why study the humanities?' with two concrete examples.
- [ ] Learn five Nigerian cultural reference points you can use accurately.
- [ ] Analyse a film scene for staging, costume and camera choices.
- [ ] Exchange answers with a coursemate and mark each other for evidence, not length.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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